

What the Postcard Said

A postcard arrived addressed to someone who had been dead for ten years. Someone had to find out why.

CEFR Level A2

Book 4 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A terraced house in a small English town. The local library and a coastal town.

Genre: Mystery / Gentle Drama

Characters

- Nina — 44. Secondary school English teacher. Methodical, patient, loves a puzzle.
- Colin — 47. Nina's husband. Supportive, slightly sceptical.
- Patrick — 82. The neighbour who knew the previous owner.
- The postcard sender — revealed gradually.

Nina found the postcard on a Wednesday morning when she went to collect the post.

It was a picture postcard — a photograph of a beach somewhere sunny. The address was written in blue ink, in a clear, rounded hand.

But the name was not hers, and it was not her husband's.

It said: For Mrs. E. Hartley, 14 Alderton Road.

This was 14 Alderton Road. But Nina and Colin had lived here for seven years, and there had been no Mrs. Hartley here when they moved in.

Nina turned the postcard over.

The message on the back was short. The same rounded handwriting.

It said:

Dear Elspeth, I still think about that summer. I hope you are well. The sea is the same as always. — R.

Nina read it twice. Then she showed it to Colin over breakfast.

'Someone wrote to the wrong address,' Colin said.

'No,' Nina said. 'The address is exactly right. They just didn't know that Elspeth doesn't live here anymore.'

'Elspeth,' Colin said. He tried the name. 'Old-fashioned name.'

'Elspeth Hartley,' Nina said. 'I wonder who she was.'

Nina knocked on Patrick's door that evening. He had lived next door for thirty years.

'Elspeth Hartley?' Patrick said. He said the name quietly, as if he was careful with it.

'Yes. Did you know her?' 'I did. She lived at number fourteen for about twenty-five years. She moved out about — oh, twelve years ago now.'

'Is she still alive?' Nina asked.

Patrick looked at his feet. 'No. She died about ten years ago. Stroke. She was in her mid-seventies.'

'What was she like?' 'Very private. Quiet. She had a lot of books. She used to grow tomatoes.'

Nina looked at the postcard more carefully that evening.

The stamp was from Portugal. The postmark showed a town on the Algarve coast.

She looked at the photograph on the front — a wide sandy beach, a clear blue sea, white buildings in the background.

She turned it over again. The sea is the same as always. R. was writing from Portugal. R. had been writing — possibly for years — to someone who had been dead for a decade.

Nina felt something she always felt at the start of a good puzzle. A quiet pull.

The next Saturday, Nina went to the library.

She told the librarian what she was looking for — historical records of the address, any mention of E. Hartley.

The librarian — a young man with reading glasses — was delighted.

'We have electoral rolls going back to the 1970s,' he said. 'And some local newspaper archives.'

They found Elspeth Hartley in the 1985 electoral roll. She was listed as: Hartley, Elspeth M. Age group: 41-50.

'So she was born around 1940,' Nina said. 'And she moved to the street in 1985 or before.'

That evening, Colin looked up from his book.

'Have you considered just returning the postcard?' he said.

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Nina receives a postcard addressed to a woman who died years ago.

'To whom?' Nina said.

'To R. You know the town in Portugal. You could write to the address on the back.'

Nina looked at the postcard. There was no return address.

'There's no address,' she said.

'Right,' Colin said. He went back to his book. Then: 'You could write to the post office in the town. They might know.'

Nina looked at him. 'That's surprisingly helpful,' she said. 'For you.'

Colin smiled without looking up.

Write to the post office. A simple idea. Nina should have thought of it.

Nina wrote the letter in English and then, with help from an online translator, in Portuguese.

She explained that she had received a postcard addressed to Mrs. E. Hartley, who had previously lived at her address but had passed away some years ago.

She said that if the sender — R. — was known to the post office or the local community, she hoped they could pass on the message.

She included a photocopy of the postcard.

She addressed it to: The Post Office, and included the town name from the postmark.

She posted it on a Monday. Then she waited.

While she waited, Nina went back to Patrick.

'Do you know if Elspeth had a friend in Portugal?' she asked.

Patrick thought for a long time.

'She went to Portugal,' he said. 'Every summer. For at least ten years. She used to ask me to water her tomatoes.'

'Every summer,' Nina said.

'She always came back with wine. Good wine.' Patrick smiled at the memory. 'She said she had friends there. Old friends. I don't know who.'

'She never talked about them specifically?' 'No. Elspeth was private. But she came back happy.'

Three weeks later, a letter arrived. It had a Portuguese stamp and was written in careful, slightly formal English.

Dear Mrs. Hamilton, Thank you for your letter. We passed your message to a resident here who receives letters for this address. She asked me to write to you. Her name is Rosa. She has been sending postcards to her friend Elspeth for fifteen years. She did not know that Elspeth had died. She is very sad to hear this. She asks: did Elspeth have family? She would like to write to them, if that is possible.

Yours sincerely, M. Ferreira, Post Office.

Nina read the letter twice. Then she went next door to Patrick.

Patrick did not know of any family. He thought Elspeth had a brother somewhere, but he had never met him.

Nina went to the library again. With more information now — a birth year, the name Elspeth M. Hartley — she found a brief obituary in a local newspaper from 2014.

It named a brother: David Hartley, of Norwich.

Nina searched online. She found a David Hartley in Norwich — a retired teacher, a few years younger than Elspeth would have been.

She wrote him a letter.

David Hartley called Nina on a Thursday evening.

He had a slow voice and spoke carefully, as if choosing each word.

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Patrick helps Nina begin tracing the postcard's story.

'You found Rosa,' he said. Not a question.

'I found that she exists,' Nina said. 'I don't know much about her.'

'Rosa and my sister met in 1978,' David said. 'In Portugal. Elspeth was travelling alone — this was unusual for a woman then. Rosa was a local teacher. They became friends immediately.'

'For how long?' 'Until Elspeth died, I suppose. Though they lost touch for many years.'

David told Nina the rest of the story.

Elspeth and Rosa had kept in touch through letters for many years. Then Elspeth's husband died, and Elspeth went through a difficult period.

She stopped writing to many people, including Rosa.

'Rosa kept writing though,' David said. 'Every summer. A postcard. Elspeth told me once that she always meant to reply, but the time kept passing.'

'And then she died,' Nina said. 'Before she replied.'

'Yes.'

There was a silence on the line.

'I should tell Rosa,' David said. 'Properly. I should write to her.'

Nina gave David the address of the post office in Portugal.

She also gave him Rosa's name and the fact that she was a local resident — probably retired now, probably in her eighties.

'I owe her a letter,' David said. 'For my sister.'

They spoke for a few more minutes. Then David said: 'Why did you do all this? You didn't know Elspeth. You didn't know any of us.'

Nina thought. 'Someone was still thinking about her,' she said. 'That seemed important. I didn't want it to just — stop.'

After she hung up, Nina did something unexpected. She wrote her own letter to Rosa.

She introduced herself — who she was, how she had found the postcard, what she had done since.

She explained about Elspeth, about David, and about the postcards.

She said: I hope you and David write to each other. Elspeth was clearly someone worth knowing. I'm sorry I never got the chance.

She posted it with David's letter.

Then she put the original postcard on the mantelpiece in the front room, next to a small plant.

Six weeks later, David called again.

'I heard from Rosa,' he said. He sounded lighter than before.

'She's eighty-three. She still lives in the same town. She still cycles.'

'How was she?' Nina asked.

'Sad about Elspeth. But also — relieved, in a way. She said she had started to think that perhaps Elspeth had simply decided she didn't want to be found.'

'And that wasn't true,' Nina said.

'No. It wasn't. It was just — time.'

'Time,' Nina said. There was something in that word that she found both sad and forgiving.

In August, a second postcard arrived from Portugal.

This one had the same beach photograph. But the name on the front was different.

It said: For Nina Hamilton, 14 Alderton Road.

Nina opened it. The handwriting was older — less rounded than before, slightly unsteady.

Dear Nina. Thank you for finding me. The sea is still the same. I am glad that Elspeth was remembered. — Rosa.

What the Postcard Said



The postcard leads Nina toward an old story that still matters.

Nina read it standing in the hallway.

She went and put it next to the original, on the mantelpiece.

Nina showed the second postcard to Patrick.

He read it standing on his doorstep.

'The sea is the same as always,' he said, reading Rosa's words aloud. 'That's what the first one said too.'

'Yes,' Nina said.

Patrick was quiet. Then: 'Elspeth used to say the same thing. Every time she came back from Portugal. She'd say — the sea doesn't change. Only we do.'

Nina looked at him. 'She said that?' 'Many times. It was something she believed in, I think.'

Nina went home and wrote it in her notebook.

That evening, Colin asked to see the postcards.

He looked at both of them for a while.

'So it started with a dead woman getting a postcard,' he said, 'and ended with you getting one from an eighty-three-year-old woman in Portugal?'

'More or less,' Nina said.

'And her brother David is writing to Rosa now?' 'Yes.'

'And Patrick told you something Elspeth used to say about the sea?'

'Yes.' Colin nodded slowly. 'It's like a very small and very complete story,' he said.

'Most real stories are,' Nina said.

In September, Nina planted tomatoes in the back garden for the first time.

She wasn't sure why. She had never grown vegetables before.

Colin watched her from the kitchen window. 'Are you going to be able to keep those alive?' he called.

'Probably not,' Nina said. 'But I want to try.'

Patrick leaned over the fence. 'Elspeth used to grow tomatoes in that exact spot,' he said. 'She used to say the soil was very good there.'

Nina looked at the soil. She patted it down.

'Then it should be fine,' she said.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. postcard	kartpostal
2. collect the post	postayı almak
3. rounded hand	yuvarlak el yazısı
4. addressed	adreslenmiş
5. moved in	taşındı
6. old-fashioned	eski moda
7. wonder	merak etmek
8. the same as always	her zaman olduğu gibi
9. wrong address	yanlış adres
10. short	kısa
11. stroke	felç
12. private	çekingen, özel
13. grow tomatoes	domates yetiştirmek
14. moved out	taşındı
15. mid-seventies	yetmişlerinin ortasında
16. stamp	pul
17. postmark	posta damgası
18. decade	on yıl
19. pull	çekim, çekici duygu
20. electoral roll	seçmen kütüğü
21. archives	arşivler
22. listed as	... olarak kayıtlı
23. delighted	çok memnun
24. going back to	... yılına kadar uzanan
25. considered	düşündü mü
26. return the postcard	kartpostali iade etmek
27. surprisingly	şaşırtıcı şekilde
28. post office	postane
29. write to	... e yazmak
30. translator	çevirmen
31. previously	daha önce
32. passed away	vefat etti
33. photocopy	fotokopi
34. included	dahil etti
35. water her tomatoes	domateslerini sulamak
36. good wine	iyi şarap
37. memory	hatıra
38. specifically	özellikle

39. came back happy	mutlu döndü
40. resident	sakin, bölge sakini
41. receives letters	mektup alıyor
42. sincerely	saygılarımla
43. passed your message	mesajınızı ilettik
44. possible	mümkün
45. obituary	ölüm ilanı
46. brief	kısa
47. retired teacher	emekli öğretmen
48. younger than	... dan daha genç
49. named a brother	bir erkek kardeşten bahsetti
50. slow voice	yavaş ses
51. choosing each word	her kelimeyi seçerek
52. travelling alone	yalnız seyahat
53. lost touch	iletişimi kesti
54. local teacher	yerel öğretmen
55. went through a difficult	period
56. kept in touch	iletişimde kaldı
57. silence on the line	hatta sessizlik
58. the time kept passing	zaman geçip durdu
59. properly	düzgünce
60. owe	borçlu olmak
61. local resident	bölge sakini
62. spoke for a few minutes	birkaç dakika konuştular
63. just stop	sadece bitmek
64. seemed important	önemli göründü
65. introduced herself	kendini tanıttı
66. unexpected	beklenmedik
67. original postcard	orijinal kartpostal
68. worth knowing	tanımaya değer
69. hung up	telefonu kapattı
70. lighter	daha hafif (ses için)
71. relieved	rahatlamış
72. decided	karar verdi
73. forgiving	affedici
74. simply	sadece
75. unsteady	titrek, kararsız
76. hallway	hol

77. glad	memnun
78. older handwriting	yaşlı el yazısı
79. still the same	hâlâ aynı
80. doorstep	kapı eşiği
81. aloud	sesli olarak
82. believed in	inanırdı
83. notebook	defter
84. only we do	sadece biz değişiriz
85. more or less	az çok, aşağı yukarı
86. complete	eksiksiz
87. dead woman	ölmüş kadın
88. looked at	baktı
89. small and complete	küçük ve eksiksiz
90. planted	dikti
91. vegetables	sebzeler
92. soil	toprak
93. patted down	patlatarak bastırdı
94. leaned over the fence	çite yaslandı
95. keep alive	canlı tutmak

After-Reading Activities

Page 20 — The Mantelpiece

By winter, the mantelpiece had three things on it.

The original postcard from Rosa to Elspeth.

Rosa's postcard to Nina.

A small photograph that David had sent — Elspeth in Portugal, in the 1980s, standing on a beach, squinting into the sun.

She was laughing. She looked exactly like someone worth knowing.

Nina dusted the mantelpiece carefully every week. She didn't know why exactly. It just felt like the right thing to do.

Outside, winter came. The tomatoes were gone.

Next year, she would try again.

Vocabulary Support

squinting

gözlerini kısıyor

dusted

tozunu aldı

carefully

dikkatle

worth knowing

tanımaya değer

next year

gelecek yıl

Three things on the mantelpiece. A woman she never knew, remembered carefully.

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

Word

Meaning

1. postcard

A. arşiv

- 2. archive
- B. kartpostal
- 3. obituary
- C. mümkün
- 4. possible
- D. ölüm ilanı
- 5. relieved
- E. rahatlamış
- 6. deliberate
- F. forgiving
- 7. forgiving
- G. affedici
- 8. resident
- H. bölge sakini

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

postcard — private — relief — summer — remembered — time

- 1. A _____ arrived addressed to a woman who had been dead for ten years.
- 2. Elspeth was very _____ — she did not talk much about her personal life.
- 3. Rosa had been sending postcards every _____ for fifteen years.
- 4. Elspeth always meant to reply — but _____ kept passing.
- 5. Rosa felt _____ when she learned the truth — it was not rejection.
- 6. Elspeth is _____ in a house she never lived in, on a mantelpiece she never saw.

Answer Key

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Nina knows who Mrs. Hartley is when the postcard arrives.

2. The postcard is from Spain. ___

3. Patrick knew Elspeth when she lived on the street. ___

4. Elspeth had no family. ___

5. David is Elspeth's son. ___

6. Rosa sends a postcard to Nina at the end. ___

Short Answer Questions

7. What was unusual about the postcard Nina received?

8. What does the message on the postcard say?

9. How does Nina find out about R. and Portugal?

10. What does Patrick remember about Elspeth and Portugal?

11. How does Nina locate Elspeth's brother?

12. Why had Elspeth stopped writing to Rosa?

13. What does Rosa say when she hears that Elspeth has died?

14. What does Nina do after she speaks to David?

15. What does Nina plant in the garden, and why is this significant?